

Web watch

Facebook is becoming politician friendly, eBay India starts new same day delivery service and more...

App watch

The best apps to watch out for this month will keep you entertained, updated and informed

What's new in the mobile space?

There's certainly more to look forward to than a WhatsApp deal with Facebook. There's Ubuntu phones, aromatic SMSes, major launches, and not-so-minor updates. Read on for your monthly quick fix

HTC One successor to be unveiled on March 25

HTC will officially unveil its new flagship smartphone – a successor to the current flagship HTC One – at an event in London on March 25. “The best is about to get better,” said HTC UK on Twitter along with a ‘Save the Date’ image.

Codenamed HTC M8, the HTC smartphone will be called either HTC One 2 or HTC One+.

The next HTC phone will have a 5-inch 1080p display, Snapdragon 800 chipset, 2GB RAM and twin UltraPixel cameras (resolution unknown but expected to be over 4MP) with dual LED flash.

The March 25 event indicates that HTC may keep a low profile at MWC 2014 in Barcelona, where many had thought that the company would give them a peek at its new flagship smartphone. Apparently, the company wants complete media attention when it announces the new flagship phone, rather than have the news buried among other announcements.

Facebook acquires WhatsApp for \$19b

Facebook officially announced the acquisition of the massively popular mobile messenger WhatsApp in February for



HTC One 2/One+ coming soon

a total of approximately \$16 billion, including \$4 billion in cash and approximately \$12 billion worth of Facebook shares. The agreement also includes an additional \$3 billion in restricted stock units for WhatsApp's founders and employees that will be released in over four years subsequent to closing. Also, WhatsApp co-founder and CEO Jan Koum will join Facebook's Board of Directors.

The acquisition comes at a time when WhatsApp has already built a huge user base – 450 million monthly users worldwide. WhatsApp has

continued to see strong growth and is adding over 1 million new registered users per day. WhatsApp's messaging volume has already totalled the entire global telecom's SMS volume.

Mark Zuckerberg, Facebook founder and CEO said, “WhatsApp is on a path to connect 1 billion people. The services that reach that milestone are all incredibly valuable. I've known Jan for a long time and I'm excited to partner with him and his team to make the world more open and connected.”

Jan Koum, WhatsApp co-founder and CEO said, “WhatsApp's extremely high user engagement and rapid growth are driven by the simple, powerful and instantaneous messaging capabilities we provide. We're excited and honored to partner with Mark and Facebook as we continue to bring our product to more people around the world.”

The Facebook-WhatsApp deal is considered to be the biggest Internet deal since Time Warner Inc.'s \$124 billion merger with AOL Inc. in 2001.

Of late, Facebook had been facing stiff competition from mobile messaging apps such as WhatsApp, WeChat, Kakao Talk, Snapchat, Line, BBM and Viber. Recognising the threat, Facebook has eaten up the com-

petition and apparently become the leader in the mobile messaging space by this acquisition.

It will be interesting to see whether Facebook will bring ads to the mobile messaging app, as the social networking giant has been looking to make money from the mobile platform. However, WhatsApp co-founder and CEO Jan Koum has been against advertisements.

WhatsApp in a blog post said: “WhatsApp will remain autonomous and operate independently. You can continue to enjoy the service for a nominal fee. You can continue to use WhatsApp no matter where in the world you are, or what smartphone you're using. And you can still count on absolutely no ads interrupting your communication. There would have been no partnership between our two companies if we had to compromise on the core principles that will always define our company, our vision and our product.”

The world's slimmest smartphone

Gionee has announced the world's slimmest smartphone, the Elife S5.5, which is only 5.5mm thick. The Elife S5.5 beats all records as it is slimmer than the 5.75mm thick Vivo X3 smartphone and the 5.8mm